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Baseballers dismayed by small turnouts

By Bob MacDonald

On some campuses, students take pride in their baseball team and show up in the thousands to support them. Such is not the case at UT El Paso.

"A lot of people on this campus don't even know we have a baseball team," says Mike Miller, a member of Andy Cohen's squad. "Sometimes it's almost funny when you see only about 30 to 40 people in the stands at our games."

THIS IS in sharp contrast with teams such as Arizona State which usually have 5,000 spectators attending their games.

"Yeah, it's really different when we play at A-State," says Miller. "Those people come to the games and have a good time. They soak up the sun and razz the players and

just enjoy themselves."

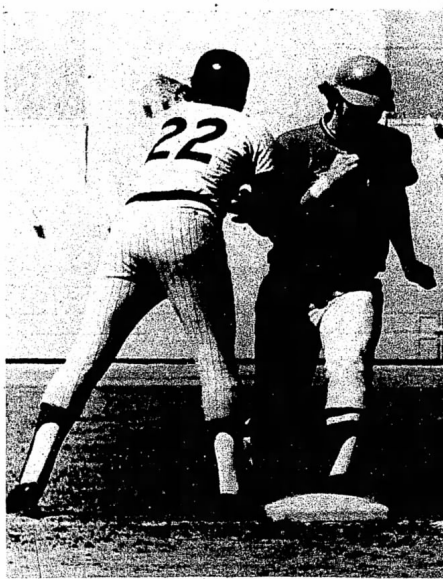
Miller is a 6-5, 200 pound catcher for the Miner baseball team. Last year as a freshman, Miller was a pitcher and compiled a 4-1 won-lost record. But this season he returns to catcher, the position that he played for three years in high school.

"WE WERE SHORT on catchers this year," commented Miller, "so coach Cohen asked me if I wanted to be a catcher again. Since I think it's easier for me to be a catcher I went ahead and made the switch."

"About the only effect the change has had on me," Miller continued, "is that I have to concentrate more on hitting." Last year as a pitcher Mike never came to the plate, as the designated hitter rule was in effect. In last week's series against Ranger Junior College, he hit a home run in his first game and in the second went four for four with an equal number of runs batted in.

COMMENTING ON the Miner team, Miller said, "We look real good in the infield and the outfield. The outfield is the best I've seen with Roy Stringer in left and Herb von Hagen in center. I guess our only weakness is our pitching and that's only because most of them are freshmen and sophomores."

"I'm hoping we have a good season this year," Miller concluded. "Then maybe we could get more people to come to the games."



Safe retreat

MINER BOB DOWNING beats a pickoff throw to first baseman Gene Marcibios in weekend baseball action at Dudley Field against Ranger JC. The Miners won three of four games. (Photo by Marty Duffily)

February 28

The Way I See It

By Bob MacDonald

Over the past few weeks a bitter controversy has developed due to an article that was written by yours truly in the Feb. 7 issue of the Prospector.

Unfortunately, the story did not appear in the form of a column as was intended. The article dealt with the baseball program at UT El Paso. Specifically, it called for an overhaul of the present program and asked that baseball be brought to a level that would make it competitive.

However many people mistook the article as an "axe-job" on Andy Cohen. Herald-Post sportswriter Pete Ciccarelli even went so far as to devote an entire column to lambasting myself and the Prospector not being nice to Cohen. In the process Mr. Ciccarelli stated some things that never appeared in the article and made some unfounded statements concerning the newspaper.

It seems absurd to me, but it was felt by many that I should have been more careful in the way the story was written. So, here is a repeat of what was said.

Baseball ranks at the very bottom of intercollegiate athletics at UT El Paso campus. This is substantiated by the amount of money spent on the sport in comparison with football, basketball and soccer. Baseball continues to struggle along with a make-shift program and does so until a new system is installed.

If a new program was to be instituted it could well mean the end of Andy Cohen as coach since in the system baseball operates under no one practically runs the entire show as far as Miner baseball is concerned.

There is nothing personal in this. Black and white facts show that Andy Cohen has been coach for 11 years and in those years baseball has never ventured far above the line of mediocrity.

In a nutshell, that was the story. I did not lurk in the dark looking for a stab at Andy Cohen in the back as Ciccarelli so eloquently stated. I just fed up with the baseball program being a joke in this town and some opponents. Nothing more needs to be said about the subject. I can only hope that the people who have the power to make changes look into this problem and act accordingly.

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